

Question: What does "present truth" or "truth for this time" mean?

Answer: Present truth is not a different gospel. It is the truth God's people especially need for the time they are living in.

Ask first what phase of God's work is at the center in a given period. Ellen White's own point is that there are many precious truths in the Word of God, but present truth is what the flock needs now. So the question is not whether other doctrines are true. The question is which truths are especially urgent for the hour God's people are living in.

Walk through redemptive history. When Christ was born, present truth was that the Messiah had come. When John the Baptist announced Christ's ministry, that was present truth for that hour. At Pentecost, present truth centered on Christ entering His priestly work. In 1844, present truth centered on the cleansing of the sanctuary. Each stage had truth for that time because each stage highlighted what Christ was then doing.

So for the present time, the governing center is what Jesus is doing now in the heavenly sanctuary, especially in the most holy place. That is why the sanctuary in connection with the 2300 days, the commandments of God, the faith of Jesus, the Sabbath, the state of the dead, and the judgment are treated as present truth. These truths explain the Advent movement, show where God's people stand, steady the doubting, and give certainty about what lies ahead.

That does not make the rest of Scripture unimportant. All truth is precious. But the burden of the message must stay on the truths the flock needs now, not on side subjects that pull attention away from what unites God's people and sanctifies the soul.

Question: Will both immature and mature believers be sealed before probation closes?

Answer: Yes, but the source does not answer that by opening a sealing passage and walking through it verse by verse. It answers it from the end-time situation they are assuming.

Start with that setting. God will still call people out of Babylon near the end, and many of them will not have had long years to mature inside the church before the close of probation. That is why 11th-hour workers matter here. Some people will come in late.

But late is not the same thing as shallow. Their point is that these believers may be latecomers in time and still grow faithfully with the light they receive. By God's grace they can accept the Sabbath truth, submit to God's authority, and reject a counterfeit system of worship.

That is where the final test comes in. The issue is loyalty, not seniority. The world will be pressed to choose between God's authority and a counterfeit Christianity enforcing Sunday in place of the Sabbath. On that logic, those who are sealed are not measured mainly by how many years they have been in the church, but by whether they have surrendered and obeyed what Christ has shown them.

So there will be 11th-hour workers, and their growth can be accelerated under the stress of the final crisis and the power of the loud cry. Some who come in late may grow faster than people who have been in the church a long time. Maturity, as they are using the idea here, is not measured by calendar time but by the depth of surrender and obedience to known truth.

Question: What does 1 Timothy 5:22 mean about not sharing in the sins of others?

Answer: The verse is about ordaining church leaders, not about praying for others.

Read it in context. From 1 Timothy 5:17 onward, Paul is giving Timothy instructions on elders -- how they are to be examined, honored, rebuked, and set apart. Verses 21 and 22 sit inside that block. "Do not lay hands on anyone hastily, nor share in other people's sins. Keep yourself pure." The laying on of hands here is ordination. Paul is warning Timothy that if he commissions a man who is not ready or not qualified, Timothy becomes responsible for the sins and failures that follow. That is how a person "shares in the sins of others" in this passage. Keeping yourself pure, in this context, means not contaminating yourself by a hasty or political appointment.

The qualifications themselves are strict enough to show why haste is dangerous. In 1 Timothy 3, a bishop must be blameless, the husband of one wife, temperate, sober-minded, hospitable, able to teach, not given to wine, not violent, not greedy, gentle, not quarrelsome, not covetous, ruling his own house well. Titus 1 repeats the same kind of list for elders: blameless, not self-willed, not quick-tempered, not given to wine, not violent, not greedy, hospitable, a lover of good, sober-minded, just, holy, self-controlled, holding fast the faithful word. You cannot evaluate a person against that list in five minutes. It takes a trajectory of observed life and proven fruit.

So Paul is telling Timothy: do not be pressured into ordaining someone because people like him, or because he has money or standing, or because you want to fill a slot. Do not get pulled into the politics of the thing. Examine the life. Look at the fruit. Wait until the man has actually proven himself.

That same caution applies to baptism. You cannot form a Christian in two or three weeks, much less an Adventist. When candidates are rushed into the water before they have grown in knowledge and surrender, the church inherits the problems. The pattern in Scripture is gestation before birth, and real care after birth. Evangelism that neglects either of those stages fills the church with people who are not ready and leaves new believers to fend for themselves. The same principle that governs ordaining an elder governs baptizing a new member: do not be hasty, and do not take on the sins that your haste creates.

There is one further angle in the same family of texts. Romans 1:32 says of certain people that, knowing the righteous judgment of God, they "not only do the same but also approve of those who practice them." So sharing in the sins of others is not only done by ordaining the wrong man or baptizing the wrong candidate. It is also done by approving and condoning others in their sin. God holds the one who approves accountable along with the one who practices.

Question: What does it mean to heap coals of fire on an enemy's head in Proverbs 25:21-22?

Answer: Heaping coals of fire on an enemy's head is not a hidden way to punish him. It is a Hebrew idiom for the burning shame and moral awakening that comes over someone when he is met with unexpected good instead of the evil he has been doing.

Proverbs 25:21-22 says, "If your enemy is hungry, give him bread to eat; and if he is thirsty, give him water to drink: for so you will heap coals of fire upon his head, and the Lord will reward you." The instruction is straightforward. Do not repay evil with evil. Repay evil with good. Feed the one who opposes you. Meet his need. Serve him. The "coals of fire" are what that kindness produces in him, not a secret revenge dressed up as love. It is not passive aggression. It is not covert vengeance. It is the piercing conviction that settles on a man when his hostility is answered with mercy.

First Samuel 24 shows the pattern in action. Saul with three thousand men was hunting David. Saul went into a cave where David was hiding. David had every opportunity to kill him. Instead David cut off the border of Saul's garment, let him leave unharmed, and then called out to him publicly and showed him the evidence of the mercy he had just received. Saul's response, in verses 16 and 17, is exactly the shame-and-awakening the proverb describes: "Is this your voice, my son David? And Saul lifted up his voice, and wept. And he said to David, You are more righteous than I: for you have rewarded me good, whereas I have rewarded you evil." That is what coals of fire on the head looks like. The enemy is convicted by the kindness.

Paul takes the same proverb into the New Testament in Romans 12:19-20. "Beloved, avenge not yourselves, but rather give place unto wrath: for it is written, Vengeance is mine; I will repay, says the Lord. Therefore if your enemy hungers, feed him; if he thirsts, give him drink: for in so doing you shall heap coals of fire on his head." Whatever else it means, Paul is plainly using it to forbid personal revenge. Leave vengeance to God, and go on doing good.

Some have taken the image a step further and read the fire as a symbol of the Holy Spirit bringing conviction, so that kindness wins a friend. That is offered as an interpretation, not as what the text itself says in so many words. What the text does say is plain enough: do not take revenge, meet the need of the one who opposes you, and trust God to reward it. In its wider context that is what Micah 6:8 calls for -- do justly, love mercy, walk humbly with God -- even, and especially, under opposition.

Question: What is the mark of the beast according to the Bible, and is it a microchip or biometric system?

Answer: The mark of the beast is not a microchip, barcode, biometric scan, or some other tracking device. Those things may become mechanisms of control, but they are not the mark itself.

Read Revelation 13 first. The chapter speaks about beasts, worship, authority, and the enforcement of allegiance. That is why the first distinction matters so much. Separate the mark of the beast from the mechanism used to enforce it. A cashless system, a digital control grid, or some other technology could be used to restrict buying and selling, but that would only be the tool used to pressure conscience. It would not itself be the mark.

Then identify the powers in Revelation 13. The first beast is identified as the papal power. The second beast is identified as the United States, which eventually raises up an image to the beast and enforces its demands. So the issue is not mainly economics or technology. The issue is worship and whose authority you submit to.

That is where Sunday comes in. The argument is that the papacy itself claims Sunday as the sign of its authority, because it claims power to change God's law from Sabbath to Sunday. On that reading, Sunday observance right now is not yet the mark of the beast simply because there has not yet been a universal legal test compelling worship on that basis. The mark becomes the mark in the full prophetic sense when Sunday observance is enforced by law and the world is pressed to choose between God's authority and the authority of a rival religious system.

Keep that qualification in view. Not every sincere Sundaykeeper already has the mark of the beast. They explicitly say that crisis point has not yet come, that many sincere Christians are serving God according to the light they presently have, and that the final test comes when the issue is made clear and conscience is forced.

That turns the issue into a Bible-versus-tradition question. If a person says he goes by the

Bible only, yet keeps Sunday where Scripture does not command Sunday as the new day of worship, then the real question becomes whose authority he is accepting. In that framework the mark of the beast is bound up with accepting human religious authority over God's expressed will.

They also set the mark over against God's sign. Quoting a statement that cites Exodus 31:13, they identify the Sabbath as God's sign or seal, because it marks Him as Creator and Sanctifier. In that contrast, the mark of the beast is the rival sign of rival authority. So the final issue is not technology as such. It is worship, obedience, and whether one receives God's sign or the sign of a power that claims the right to alter God's law.

Question: Where in the Bible does it say the apostolic church had practices like salutes, drills, uniforms, and marching such as Pathfinders and AY clubs do?

Answer: It does not. The apostolic church does not show salutes, drills, uniforms, or marching -- and it also does not show cooking demonstrations, health lectures, or medical cadet corps. Absence in the New Testament is not by itself a prohibition. As long as a practice does not contradict what the New Testament church did and is ordered toward the church's mission, the church is free to adopt it.

Pathfinders and the youth clubs work as auxiliary organizations. They give young people constructive outlets for enormous energy, teach discipline, order, cleanliness, and cooperation, draw families into the church through their children, and retain members over the long term. In some parts of the world, like Panama's Mission Caleb, Pathfinders in uniform paint houses, cut grass, and clean communities.

The clubs can go off track -- camporees with dancing after Sabbath has begun, clubs that become pure entertainment, local programs that have absorbed worldly practices. That is a real problem and it needs to be corrected. But misuse of a program does not invalidate the program. If the local leadership is biblically sound and following the actual curriculum, the club is a benefit to the youth and to the church. If it is drifting, it needs to be pulled back in love, not thrown out.

Question: Based on 1 Kings 20:35-43, is it okay to use a false name and pretend to be someone else so that an elder who has stopped responding to emails will respond?

Answer: No. Tell the truth. Leave the consequences with God.

The prophet's disguise in 1 Kings 20 is not a permission slip. Scripture describes many things it does not endorse. The Gibeonites tricked Israel and saved their lives, but ended up as slaves forever -- the trick is narrated, not commended. The prophet in 1 Kings 20 was given a specific, prophetic instruction to confront Ahab in a particular way at a particular moment. You have not been given that instruction. Lifting the narrative out as a general license for deception is the same kind of mishandling that produced the doctrine of baptism for the dead from 1 Corinthians 15:29, where Paul is only describing what some were doing, not prescribing it.

The principle is plain across Scripture. The Spirit is the Spirit of truth. Christ is the truth. Nathanael is commended because there was no guile in him. Second Thessalonians says the lost perish because they did not receive the love of the truth. No deviation from strict integrity meets God's approval. Even under real pressure, the right move is honesty: when the Gestapo came to Corrie ten Boom's house looking for a man she was hiding under a tablecloth, she told them he was right under the table, and they laughed it off and left. God is able to defend. He does not need us to take things into our own hands.

Situation ethics -- the idea that love sometimes requires you to lie, or even to commit

adultery, to secure a loving outcome -- replaces God's law with the inclinations of the heart, and Jeremiah 17 warns that the heart is deceitful above all things and only the Lord truly knows it.

Examine the motive here. If the elder has stopped responding, a fake name will not produce a godly conversation; it will produce another round of the same dispute under a mask. Pray. Let God work on the person. Consider whether your own approach needs more humility and love. If the Spirit is leading, He will open the door honestly. Deception is not that door.

Question: How should someone transition to keeping the Sabbath after discovering the truth, without simply turning his back on his former church?

Answer: If you have become convinced from Scripture that the Sabbath is truth, then honor that truth fully. Do not try to keep one foot in obedience and one foot in a church system that rejects the light God has shown you.

Once you decide to follow the Bible, other decisions follow. The real issue is not whether you feel attached to your former church. The real issue is whether the Word of God is supreme, or whether church loyalty is supreme. If your church does not teach the whole truth, then sooner or later you have to decide whether you will accommodate error or obey God.

Matthew 6:24 makes the point plainly: you cannot serve two masters. Once truth is understood, truth calls for obedience, not partial commitment. The Sabbath is not treated as a minor point either. Ezekiel 20:12 is used to show that God gave the Sabbath as a sign between Himself and His people, so keeping it is part of accepting His rulership and sanctifying work in your life.

So the transition should be real. You need to plant yourself where the truth is taught, not remain settled in a body that rejects what God has shown you. This may mean severing ties with a church as an institution.

But that does not mean severing ties with people. Keep the friendships. Cherish them. Use your influence with love and patience. Stay in contact and witness to them. Share the light you have found. The point is not to abandon people. The point is to stop participating in a system that continues in error while still trying to help the people inside it.

Do not try to live in both worlds at once. You cannot keep Sabbath privately, then continue in a Sunday church as though the doctrinal divide does not matter. Sooner or later a choice has to be made. Coming to Christ means turning your back on error, not merely adding one more truth to an otherwise unchanged life.

So transition with love, but transition decisively. Obey God rather than men. Leave partial truth behind. Keep your relationships open for witness, but do not treat membership in error as if it were spiritually neutral.

Question: How should Christians practice tithing today, especially with fixed salaries, gross-versus-net questions, financial strain, and concerns about how leaders use the money?

Answer: Treat tithing as a faith issue before you treat it as an accounting puzzle.

Tithe is not presented mainly as a financial technique but as an act of trust. If you only pay tithe when the numbers already feel comfortable, then the whole faith element

disappears. Tithing is meant to say, Lord, what I have has come from You, and I trust You enough to return what You claim as Yours.

On that basis, reject the idea that a salaried person should tithe only on the raise or only on occasional increase beyond regular wages. Each paycheck is increase when you receive it. So the tenth is taken from the salary itself, not merely from some later bump above your normal earnings.

Return tithe on the gross, not on what remains after taxes, bills, and deductions. If you wait until everything else is paid first, then God is being treated as the leftover claimant instead of the first claimant. The reasoning is simple: the tithe belongs to God before you start arranging the rest of your spending.

Hard circumstances do not remove the principle. In fact, the very pressure of limited income is where the trust element becomes real. God invites His people to prove Him, and tithing becomes one of the practical places where that trust is exercised.

Do not make another person's conduct the measure of your own faithfulness. In their Adventist frame, tithe is handled through a broader church structure rather than simply handed over as a private gift to enrich a local pastor. And even where abuses may exist elsewhere, your duty is still to return to God what is His.

When you pay tithe, you are not giving God a gift in the strict sense. You are returning what He already claims as His own. Offerings are what go beyond that. Tithe is the baseline return; offerings are the additional gift.

Question: Does 1 Corinthians 7:14 -- that the children of a mixed marriage "would be unclean, but now they are holy" -- mean children are born with a sinful nature?

Answer: No, this is not a text about a child's nature at birth. It is about the home.

Paul is addressing a couple who were both unbelievers when they married and then one spouse came to faith. He is not addressing the question of whether to enter an unequally yoked marriage. His point is that the believing spouse should not automatically divorce. The believing spouse does not become defiled by the unbelieving one; the opposite moves in. The unbelieving spouse is sanctified by the believing one, and that holy influence spills over onto the children, so that they are called holy rather than unclean. If the marriage were torn up, that sanctifying influence on the home and on the children would be lost.

So "unclean" and "holy" here describe standing inside the covenant household under the influence of a believing parent, not the ontological condition of the child. The passage is not saying anything about sinful nature in either direction.

Question: How does the seventh commandment apply to angels and other non-human beings who do not marry? And why do animals procreate if they are not repopulating heaven?

Answer: The ten commandments are eternal in principle and adapted in expression. The fourth commandment, for example, mentions the manservant and maidservant -- that is a human application of an eternal principle. The seventh commandment works the same way.

At the principle level, adultery and fornication are disloyalty. A pure woman in Scripture stands for a faithful church; a harlot stands for a church that has abandoned Christ and joined herself to the kings of the earth. Revelation's harlot committing

fornication with the kings is that union of church and state -- and it is a violation of the seventh commandment in principle. Paul uses the same logic when he tells believers not to be unequally yoked with unbelievers. Lucifer is the original fornicator in that sense: he forsook Christ and fell in love with himself, coveted a position that was not his, and in principle broke every one of the ten commandments. So the seventh commandment applies to every moral being in the universe. It governs loyalty, not only human sexuality.

On animals: they procreate because the ecosystem of this world requires it. God created animals for the life of the earth, foresaw sin and death entering, and gave them the capacity to replenish so that the order of nature would continue. Genesis 1:28, where God tells the humans to be fruitful and multiply and have dominion, sets up the human-animal relationship as stewardship, not exploitation. Animals multiply to serve nature's balance and to serve humanity's life on earth. That is the purpose; repopulating heaven is not.

Question: Can you show from the Bible only that the saints will hear the day and hour of Christ's coming?

Answer: There is no single Bible verse that states, "God will announce the day and the hour." The speakers acknowledge that directly. What the Bible does give is the surrounding scene, and the announcement fits inside it.

This is after the close of probation, at the very end of the time of trouble, when every case is already decided. Revelation 16:17-18 places us there: the seventh angel pours out the last plague, a loud voice comes out of the temple from the throne saying, "It is done," and there are noises, thunderings, lightnings, and the greatest earthquake in human history. Whenever Scripture describes thundering, lightnings, and earthquake together, God is about to say something weighty -- Sinai at the giving of the ten commandments is the pattern. So the moment in Revelation 16 is already a moment in which God speaks.

Inside that scene, the living righteous are glorified, and there is a special resurrection -- those who pierced Him, and those who died in the faith of the third angel's message, which Revelation 14:13 marks with "blessed are those who die in the Lord from now on." Then Christ comes, and when He is above the earth the general resurrection of those who died before 1844 takes place, which Daniel 12:1-2 describes as the awakening of those who sleep in the dust.

So when Ellen White says in *The Great Controversy* that the voice from heaven announces the day and the hour, she is filling in a detail inside a sequence the Bible already gives. It does not contradict Christ's "no man knows the day or the hour," because that statement refers to our current knowledge before probation closes. After "It is done," the living righteous hear it because the decision has already been made and the deliverance is underway.

Question: Is it wrong to crochet on Sabbath while listening to Bibles or sermons to keep my hands busy, if it is not to sell?

Answer: No moral issue here. Do not build lists of Sabbath rules that Scripture does not build. The biblical principles are plain -- do not buy or sell, do not engage in secular work -- and inside those principles God has given you a conscience. A sanctified conscience is the instrument that leads you to the right answer in your own case.

The question already carries its own answer. You are not doing this for gain; you are doing it because your hands need something to do in order for your mind to stay focused on the Word. That is not secular work; it is an aid to worship. If the crocheting were

producing items to sell it would be a different question. If the items are a blessing to someone else -- sweaters for the homeless or people in need -- that is service, not labor.

Do not let others become your conscience. Ask the Lord to show you, keep the Sabbath holy from the heart, and do what actually helps you hear the Word.

Question: Why did the veil separating the holy and most holy place in the heavenly sanctuary continue to exist until 1844? How do we reconcile the rending of the earthly veil at the cross with Christ's two-phase priestly ministry in heaven?

Answer: The rending of the veil at Christ's death signified the end of the earthly sanctuary system, not the abolition of the heavenly sanctuary or its phases. Hebrews 8 says the earthly tabernacle was only a type and shadow of the true heavenly reality. When Jesus died, the veil of His flesh was torn, putting an end to the validity of earthly animal sacrifices in the sense explained by Daniel 9 and opening direct access to God through Christ.

However, the heavenly sanctuary still operates with two distinct apartments. The book of Revelation shows Jesus first ministering in the holy place, walking among the candlesticks and standing at the altar of incense. Later, in 1844, Revelation 3 describes a door being closed (the holy place) and an open door being placed before the church (the most holy place), transitioning Christ's ministry to the final phase of judgment where the Ark of His Testament is seen (Revelation 11:19). The torn veil on earth simply meant the shadow had met its reality in the death of the Son of God; it did not collapse the sequential ministry Christ was about to begin in heaven.

Question: Who served as the high priest in the heavenly sanctuary before Jesus's inauguration as our high priest at His ascension?

Answer: Strictly speaking, no one served as a fully inaugurated high priest before Christ, because the blood of bulls and goats could not actually remove sin. In the Old Testament, God passed over sins on credit, as Romans 3:25 explains. Salvation was always through faith in the coming Savior, whose future sacrifice guaranteed their pardon.

Jesus was the designated intercessor in God's plan even before sin existed, and He began interceding for humanity the moment Adam and Eve fell. However, to officially become the High Priest, He had to meet specific qualifications: He had to become human, experience our weaknesses, and offer a real, effective sacrifice for sin, which is the point made in Hebrews 5. Only after dying on the cross could He ascend to heaven with His own blood to formally anoint the heavenly sanctuary, in line with Daniel 9:24, and be inaugurated as our High Priest, turning the promise of Old Testament salvation into a paid reality.

Question: If the ten northern tribes lost their pure lineage in the Assyrian captivity, how could Elizabeth be identified as from the tribe of Levi and Anna as from the tribe of Asher?

Answer: Not every Israelite in the northern tribes lost their identity. A good portion intermarried with the Assyrians and the surrounding pagan nations -- that is the origin of the Samaritans -- but a remnant in each tribe remained faithful and kept the line. Josiah's reformation shows it clearly: when he reached into the territory of the northern tribes, there were people there who returned to the Lord.

Levi is the easiest case, because the tribe of Levi was tied to the sanctuary service in Judah. Many Levites returned with the post-exilic community to Jerusalem, so Elizabeth's Levitical descent in the New Testament is not a surprise. Anna from the tribe

of Asher is the harder case, but the same principle applies: some remained, kept records, and preserved their tribal identity through the captivity and after. By the New Testament period, tribal identity also does not necessarily imply pure blood. Paul calls himself a Benjamite while living in Gentile territory. Intermarriage happened throughout the Old Testament and people still counted as Israelites. So Elizabeth and Anna being named from their tribes reflects a preserved line, not a claim of genetic purity across seven centuries.

Question: How can God sanction one nation attacking and killing another, as with Israel and the Moabites in 2 Kings 3?

Answer: God does not destroy a nation arbitrarily. He destroys it when it has gone beyond the point of no return, and only He knows when that line is crossed.

Genesis 15 sets the pattern. God promised Abraham the land but delayed its possession by four hundred years "because the iniquity of the Amorite is not yet full." Probation, in effect, had not closed on them. By the time of Moses, several generations later, that fullness had been reached. That is when the judgment falls. The same principle governs the Flood, Sodom and Gomorrah, and the final destruction of the wicked at Christ's coming. If destroying the wicked at the end is consistent with divine justice -- and Scripture says it is -- then the Old Testament judgments follow the same logic.

God's preferred method was not military conquest. Exodus 23 promised to drive the Canaanites out little by little through the hornet and the wild beasts of the land. That plan required faith. Israel's unbelief forced the transition to war; God still worked through them at the level they were on. So the warfare is not a picture of God's first will but of God meeting His people in their weakness while still protecting His name among the nations. In that cultural world, whichever god's people won was believed to be the stronger god, so when Israel was mocked and attacked, God's name itself was at stake.

Moab is a good example of timing. When Israel first passed through on the way to the Jordan, God told Moses not to fight Moab, Edom, or Ammon -- they were kin through Lot and Abraham, and their cup was not yet full. Later those same nations hardened further, and only then do we see the wars of 2 Kings 3 and others.

Nations can commit the unpardonable sin, just as individuals can. Babylon was told, "You have been weighed in the balances and found wanting." At the end, the wicked themselves will ask to be destroyed because they cannot stand to live in the presence of the God they have learned to despise. God is simply giving them the full result of the choice they have been making. That is the frame for Old Testament holy war: divine patience first, judgment only when the line has been crossed, and the choice always respected.

Question: If wars seem fewer now than in Old Testament times, what did Jesus mean in Matthew 24 about wars and rumors of wars as a sign of the end?

Answer: The sign is not that there are wars for the first time. Wars have always existed. What Jesus is describing is a convergence -- wars on a worldwide scale, more bloody, more repetitive, combined with all the other signs.

Matthew 24 does not begin with wars. It begins with deception -- false Christs, counterfeit spiritual manifestations, angels pretending to be Christ. When those deceptions rise, the other signs -- wars, pestilences, earthquakes -- are already being fulfilled, but now in greater intensity and frequency. The First and Second World Wars are a pattern the ancient world never saw. Old Testament wars were regional, largely confined to Asia and later Europe. Today the contest is global, with the major powers

drawing the nations into their alignment.

And Matthew 24 is not the only list. Revelation adds the ascent of the United States in global power, the healing of the wound of the papacy, and more. Ellen White observes in *The Great Controversy* (pages 589-590) that the disasters God allows will become more frequent and more severe as the end nears. It is the accumulation -- wars, natural disasters, social unrest, deceptions, political and religious realignments -- all intensifying at the same time that constitutes the sign. That is the perfect storm Jesus is pointing at, not any single war in isolation.

Question: Why did Ellen White call the 1888 message "the third angel's message in verity," and if it had been accepted at Minneapolis would it have brought the latter rain and finished the work?

Answer: Yes. Had the message been received, it would have brought the latter rain and finished the work.

The reason Ellen White called the 1888 message the third angel's message in verity is that it restored the missing half of Revelation 14:12. The third angel ends with, "Here is the patience of the saints; here are they that keep the commandments of God and the faith of Jesus." Adventism had dwelt heavily on the commandments of God, but had not preached the faith of Jesus with the same weight. Salvation had been drifting toward works. At Minneapolis, the older pioneers accused Jones and Waggoner of undermining the law. Ellen White's response was the opposite: they were giving the law its right place by putting the faith of Jesus back where it belonged, because it is through the faith of Jesus that the commandments of God are kept.

She captured the message in *Testimonies to Ministers* pages 91-92: the 1888 message presented justification through faith in the Surety, Christ as the Surety, inviting people to receive the righteousness of Christ -- a justification that is made manifest in obedience to all the commandments of God. And in *Review and Herald*, June 4, 1895, she wrote: "Righteousness within is testified by righteousness without. The righteousness by which we are justified is imputed. The righteousness by which we are sanctified is imparted. The first is our title to heaven. The second is our fitness for heaven." You do not go to heaven with only one. The 1888 message held both together. Rejecting it did not simply delay a revival; it delayed the third angel's message in its fullness and with it the latter rain.

Question: What is the meaning of Revelation 9?

Answer: Revelation 9 should be read as part of the historicist unfolding of the trumpets, not as a chapter pushed wholesale into the future. The chapter contains the fifth and sixth trumpets, and the speakers insist that the trumpets, like the churches and the seals, move through history step by step from John's time to the end.

They do not claim every detail of Revelation 9 is settled beyond dispute. They explicitly say there are variations among Adventist interpreters on particular trumpet fulfillments. But they treat one point as non-negotiable: the trumpets are not to be read as entirely future. In their reasoning, Revelation 10 stands inside the sixth trumpet as a parenthesis, and Revelation 10 applies to the Millerite movement and 1844. Because that section reaches into the sixth trumpet, the sixth trumpet cannot belong only to the future. And because Revelation 11 presents the seventh trumpet as the final takeover of the kingdoms of this world by the Father and Christ, the sequence is still moving toward its climax.

So the meaning of Revelation 9, in the way they answer it here, is not a full symbol-by-symbol decoding of locusts and horsemen. It is that the fifth and sixth

trumpets belong to the historic course of redemptive history, that their fulfillment stretches through past events rather than waiting entirely ahead, and that interpreters should stay with that historicist framework even where they differ on some particulars.

Question: Is the "one hour" in Revelation 17:12 a literal time prophecy?

Answer: No. The "one hour" in Revelation 17:12 is treated here as a short but indefinite period, not as a literal prophetic time calculation.

The first reason is the immediate context. Revelation 17:10 says the seventh king continues only "a short time," and verse 12 describes the ten kings receiving authority with the beast for "one hour." The speakers treat those expressions as parallel. In other words, "one hour" is John's way of describing brevity, not of supplying a calculable prophetic unit.

The second reason is how Revelation itself uses the expression. In Revelation 18 Babylon's judgment and destruction come in "one hour," but the point there is suddenness and rapid collapse, not a literal sixty-minute destruction. They make the same point from Revelation 14:7: "the hour of his judgment has come" does not mean the judgment lasts only sixty minutes.

The third reason is John's broader vocabulary. In the Gospel of John, Jesus says, "My hour has not yet come," "the hour is coming," and later, "the hour has come" for the Son of Man to be glorified. In those passages hour means an appointed time, season, or decisive moment. The speakers say Revelation uses the term the same way here.

So the ten kings receive authority with the beast for a brief, divinely noted period whose exact limits are not specified in the text. The emphasis is on short duration, not on a literal time prophecy to be mathematically computed.

Question: Does the sixth commandment forbid self-defense?

Answer: The sixth commandment forbids willful, violent, intentional taking of life. The speakers do not flatten every case of death into the same category. They say Scripture itself distinguishes between premeditated murder, accidental killing, vengeance, and cases where a death happens without lying in wait.

That is why they turn to Exodus 21 and Numbers 35. Exodus 21 says the person who strikes another so that he dies is to be put to death, but it also makes room for a case where the person did not lie in wait and may flee to the appointed place of refuge. Numbers 35 develops that distinction further. If the death was not driven by enmity or premeditation, the congregation had to investigate the case and the person could remain in the city of refuge rather than being treated as a murderer. If it was premeditated murder, the person was delivered up. In their answer, that distinction is the key.

So they do not give a hard absolutist statement that every act of self-defense is automatically sinful, and they do not give blanket approval either. They say a sudden life-or-death defense in which someone is harmed or even killed may fall under the category of a non-premeditated act rather than murder. At the same time, they openly admit they do not find a direct biblical treatment of self-defense itself.

They also add a pastoral caution. A believer should not be eager to take justice into his own hands, because vengeance belongs to God, not to us. They point to Jesus' refusal to defend Himself and raise the question whether we trust the Lord to deliver us without taking vengeance ourselves. So the answer they give is restrained: premeditation and vengeance are condemned; Scripture allows distinctions where intent and circumstance

matter; and self-defense remains a serious, complex question that should not be turned into a license for revenge.

Question: Why is the Holy Spirit sometimes referred to as "he" and other times as "it" in Scripture, as in Romans 8:26-27 and John 14-16?

Answer: The variation between "he" and "it" is a grammar issue, not a theology issue. In Greek, the word for spirit -- *pneuma* -- is grammatically neuter, and the article that goes with it is the neuter article. A literal translation can render that as "it." But when the context makes plain that the subject is the Holy Spirit and the Holy Spirit is a person, translators shift to "he" to reflect the referent rather than the grammatical gender. That is why the same translator can use both within a few verses. Nothing in the Greek requires reading the Holy Spirit as an impersonal force.

The personhood itself is settled elsewhere. The Holy Spirit is the third person of the Godhead. Ellen White wrote in Bible Training School, March 1, 1906, "There are three living persons of the heavenly trio; in the name of these three," naming Father, Son, and Holy Ghost -- and that statement is from her directly, not a compilation. So three persons is the plain teaching, even where the Greek article happens to be neuter.

Beyond that, restraint is right. Ellen White also warns in Acts of the Apostles, page 52, that the nature of the Holy Spirit is a mystery men cannot explain because the Lord has not revealed it; bringing together passages to construct a human theory on something God has left unrevealed will not strengthen the church. Silence is golden on the how. It is also worth noting that the metaphors used for the Spirit -- oil, rain, fire, dove, outpouring in the latter rain -- describe function, not substance. The Spirit is not literally a liquid being poured in; those images picture what He does. And the Holy Spirit is not simply the divine nature of Christ transferred down to earth, because Christ's divinity and humanity are not separable in that way. The Holy Spirit is His own person.

Question: If heaven has no sin or sadness, how will we remember loved ones who did not make it?

Answer: The premise needs one correction before the answer. It is not quite right to say heaven has never had sin or sadness. Sin originated in heaven, in a perfect place. And sadness is not sin -- the angels stopped their singing and laid down their harps during Christ's passion, and God Himself sorrows when people reject Him. What is true is that heaven now has no sin, because the devil has been cast out, and in the new earth there will be no more pain.

On the memory itself, start with the placement of Revelation 21:4. Revelation 20 ends with the wicked cast into the lake of fire. Revelation 21:1 is the climax of that scene: new heavens, new earth, the old passed away. Then verse 2 begins a new cycle that loops back before the destruction -- the New Jerusalem descending after the millennium, before the wicked are destroyed. Inside that earlier window comes verse 4: "And God will wipe away every tear from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain." Every verb in the surrounding passage is future from that point, and death is still present because the wicked have not yet been destroyed. So the tears God wipes away are real tears, shed by the saints inside the city over those outside the city. There will be grief. God does not pretend otherwise.

After that, the memory is not preserved as ongoing torment. Isaiah 65:17 is plain: "Behold, I create new heavens and a new earth: and the former shall not be remembered, nor come into mind." Psalm 37:34 says that when the wicked are cut off, you shall see it -- the saints will witness the judgment -- but the carrying of that memory does not belong to them forever. That is where God's promise to wipe away the tear becomes an erasure,

not a suppression. The pain of who is not there is borne eternally in the heart of God, not in ours.

Ellen White was shown this in vision. In Early Writings page 17 she was carried forward to the kingdom and met two of the 1844 pioneers who had died, Fitch and Stockman, who asked what the living had passed through. "We tried to call up our greatest trials, but they looked so small compared with a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory that surrounded us that we could not speak them out, and we all cried out, 'Hallelujah! heaven is cheap enough'; and we touched our glorious harps and made heaven's arches ring." Heaven will be so glorious that the memory of the former things will not rise to mind. The answer is not that we forget by effort but that glory and the presence of Christ displace the old.

Question: Is the Filioque how they supplant Jesus Christ with the pope?

Answer: The premise behind the question does not hold up, and the speakers say so directly. They do not see how the Filioque is connected to supplanting Christ with the pope.

What the Filioque actually is: the Latin word filioque means "and from the Son." The original creed said the Holy Spirit proceeds from the Father. Later the Western church added "and the Son," so that the Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son. The Eastern church did not accept that addition and considered it a corruption of the doctrine of the Godhead. That dispute was one of the major factors in the schism between the Eastern and Western churches. It is a serious theological and ecclesial controversy in its own right, but it is not the mechanism by which the papacy substitutes itself for Christ.

Question: Should Christians follow the Gregorian calendar?

Answer: Using the Gregorian calendar for daily life and business is perfectly acceptable and does not violate biblical principles. The calendar is a civil framework, an ordinance of men that Christians can freely navigate to maintain order in society, which is the principle drawn from 1 Peter 2.

While the names of the days may have pagan origins and the secular world operates from midnight to midnight, the actual seven-day sequential cycle established at creation remains completely unbroken. Historical calendar adjustments, such as the shift from the Julian to the Gregorian calendar in 1582, changed the dates to correct astronomical drift but never interrupted the continuous cycle of the week itself.

Therefore, you do not need to superimpose biblical timekeeping onto secular interactions. You have discretion over how you manage the six working days. The only requirement is to render to God what is God's: when Friday sundown arrives, you step out of the secular framework to faithfully observe the seventh-day Sabbath until Saturday sundown.

Question: What is the SDA Church's position on White Christian Nationalism?

Answer: The Seventh-day Adventist Church is completely against Christian nationalism. Any ideology that attempts to merge church and state to create a "Christian nation" or use political authority to enforce religion is entirely antithetical to Adventist theology and core values.

The church's historical and official stance mandates a strict separation of church and state. The church and its representatives will not align with any political party, nor will they use civil influence to advance their faith or inhibit the faith of others. True moral

change cannot be achieved through legislation or political force; it only comes through the work of the Holy Spirit in the human heart.

Furthermore, leading any movement with racial designations like "white" or "black" introduces an artificial, demonic division into the human family. God is no respecter of persons. When believers divest themselves of the desire for superiority, these racial divisions lose their power. The church's mandate is to preach the gospel to all people, not to seize the levers of government to enforce a national religion.

Question: Does Jesus see what is happening on earth directly, or through the Holy Spirit? Is He only relying on foreknowledge, and how does this relate to the Godhead and the ministry of angels?

Answer: Christ does not need to leave heaven and become locally present on earth in order to know what is happening here. God knows everything from eternity, and Christ shares that divine knowledge. At the same time, heaven does not operate in a flat, undifferentiated way. God works through an ordered administration.

That is why Revelation 1 is the starting point. The revelation is given by the Father to Jesus Christ, then passed along through an angel to John, then to the churches, and from there to the world. The Holy Spirit belongs in that line as Christ's representative on earth, because Revelation repeatedly says, "Hear what the Spirit says to the churches." The point is not that Christ is ignorant unless someone informs Him. The point is that heaven works through delegated responsibility and active communication.

Foreknowledge is not predetermination. God knew from eternity what choices would be made, but His knowing did not force those choices. He does not determine the acts and then simply watch them happen. He knows them because nothing is hidden from Him.

Psalms 139 is used to make that distinction. The psalm is not treated as teaching that God is a substance diffused through everything. It is treated as teaching that God knows everything. He knows your sitting down and rising up, your thoughts afar off, and your words before you speak them. So when the psalm says there is nowhere to flee from His presence, the point is that there is nowhere outside His knowledge, reach, and government, not that God is physically spread through every corner of creation.

On that basis, the Father remains enthroned in heaven, Christ remains in heaven interceding, and the Holy Spirit works on earth through the ministry of angels. The centurion's servant illustrates the principle: authority can act effectively at a distance through delegated agents. In the same way, God ministers to humanity through the Spirit and angels without ceasing to be the God who reigns from heaven.

So Jesus knows all that happens on earth, not because He must be bodily present everywhere, but because divine omniscience sees all things and because the Godhead works through an ordered chain of communication and agency. The Holy Spirit and the angels are not replacements for divine knowledge. They are the means by which heaven actively ministers and carries out God's will in the world.

Question: Does Armageddon happen before or after the Millennium?

Answer: Armageddon, strictly speaking, takes place before the second coming, not after the millennium.

The plagues are before the second coming, and Armageddon is tied to the sixth and seventh plagues. The sixth plague is the preparation for the battle, and the seventh plague is the battle itself when Christ comes with the armies of heaven. In that setting,

the battle is the wicked gathering against God's people. Because God's people represent Him, it is a battle against God in the person of His people.

So Armageddon is not the post-millennial attack on the New Jerusalem. It is the pre-advent crisis in which the powers of earth unite against the remnant under the last-plague setting, and God's people are delivered before Christ appears.

An important distinction still has to be kept in view. After the millennium, Satan does gather the wicked around the city. He deceives them, rallies them, and prepares them to attack the New Jerusalem. In that sense, there is a pattern after the millennium that resembles what happened before the second coming. The multitudes had already turned against the harlot and the religious leaders before the advent, and after the millennium they finally turn against Satan himself when the true history is displayed and his deception is exposed.

That resemblance is what causes confusion. What happens after the millennium can be spoken of loosely as a second stage or parallel to Armageddon. But technically speaking, Armageddon is before the second coming, when the deceived wicked turn against the religious powers and move against God's people under the sixth and seventh plagues.

So if the question is asked precisely, Armageddon belongs to the closing conflict before Christ returns. The post-millennial assault on the city is real, but it should be distinguished from Armageddon proper.

Question: Is it wrong to show physical affection -- stroking, holding -- during church service, and how should people conduct themselves in the house of God?

Answer: The purpose of the worship service is to focus on God -- to pray, sing, hear the Word, and direct attention upward. Anything that pulls that focus away, whether from the person doing it or those sitting nearby, is out of place. 1 Corinthians 14:40 is the standard: "Let all things be done decently and in order."

Physical affection between spouses is not wrong. The place for it is not the sanctuary. Carrying private expressions of intimacy into the house of God dishonors the Lord and distracts the congregation. The same applies to texting, feeding children snacks during service, or anything else that makes the common crowd out the holy. Reverence takes different forms across cultures -- some churches say amen aloud, others sit in silence -- but mishandling your spouse in the pew is out of bounds everywhere. The house of God is a house of worship.

Question: In Revelation 5:6, Jesus is described as having seven eyes which are the seven spirits of God. Does this mean Jesus sees what is happening on earth through the Holy Spirit? And is the Holy Spirit a person or a force or energy coming from the Father and the Son?

Answer: On personhood there is no ambiguity. Ellen White names three living persons of the heavenly trio -- Father, Son, and Holy Spirit -- in Bible Training School, March 1, 1906. The Holy Spirit has intelligence, can be grieved, and is volitional; John 3:8 says the Spirit blows where he wills. He convicts, sanctifies, gives gifts. He is a person.

On the nature of the Holy Spirit, restraint is right. Ellen White writes in Acts of the Apostles pages 51-52 that "the nature of the Holy Spirit is a mystery. Men cannot explain it because the Lord has not revealed it to them." Silence is golden on the how.

On the seven eyes in Revelation 5:6: the image is figurative. Seven is the number of completeness or fullness throughout Revelation, and the seven eyes symbolizing the

seven spirits of God express that Christ sees and knows all things fully -- they are not a claim that he perceives the earth only through the Holy Spirit as a separate sensory organ he lacks. John 16:7 puts it from Christ's own mouth: "If I do not go away, the Helper will not come to you; but if I depart, I will send him to you." The Spirit's presence on earth is Christ's sending, not a sign of Christ's limitation.

As for how the Father and Son remain aware of all things while the Spirit ministers on earth: Ellen White in *Ministry of Healing* page 417 writes that God is not inert on his throne but surrounded by tens of thousands of holy beings waiting to do his will; "through these messengers he is in active communication with every part of his dominion. By his spirit, he is everywhere present." The angels extend divine communication throughout creation; the Spirit is everywhere. *Desire of Ages* page 352 similarly places all the intelligences of heaven in Christ's army. The scenario the questioner fears -- that Jesus is effectively blind to the earth while interceding -- does not hold. He is the interceding high priest in the heavenly sanctuary, the Spirit is his sent representative on earth, and the angelic host carries awareness throughout creation. These are distinct roles operating in concert, not a division that leaves any part of the creation unseen.

Question: Is "Immanuel" in Isaiah 7:14 really about Jesus, and how do we explain the time-bound prophecy of verse 16?

Answer: This prophecy must be understood through biblical typology, where a historical "type" (a shadow or pattern) points to a future "antitype" (the perfect, ultimate reality).

Verse 16 had a direct, historical fulfillment in Isaiah's day: within a couple of years, the kings of Syria and Samaria (Rezin and Pekah) were killed, bringing deliverance to Judah. However, the historical type does not perfectly encompass all the details of the prophecy. Verse 14 explicitly speaks of a virgin conceiving--a biological impossibility without divine intervention. This specific sign could only find its true, perfect fulfillment in Jesus Christ.

The Old Testament frequently uses such dual applications. For example, "Out of Egypt I called my son" initially referred to the nation of Israel, but the New Testament applies it perfectly to Christ. Likewise, while Isaiah 7 had a local context, the promise of a miraculously born "God with us" points ultimately to the Messiah taking on human flesh to become our perfect Savior.

Question: How do we interpret the institution of slavery in ancient Israel, especially the lifelong servitude of non-Israelites?

Answer: Biblical slavery cannot be equated with Greco-Roman slavery or modern colonial slavery. Those later systems treated human beings as mere property to be exploited with "rigor"--the exact kind of abusive bondage Israel suffered in Egypt, which God condemned. In fact, God punished the United States for the high crime of slavery.

In ancient Israel, the system functioned more like indentured servitude or a social welfare system for debt relief. Even when foreigners became permanent servants (like the Gibeonites who tricked Joshua), they were not abused. They lived with their families, possessed land, and were grafted into Israel.

God's laws heavily regulated the practice to protect human dignity. Slaves were explicitly granted Sabbath rest and could not be worked seven days a week. Furthermore, Deuteronomy 23 explicitly commanded that if a slave escaped from an abusive master, they were not to be returned--a law that completely contradicts modern fugitive slave laws. While the system allowed for foreign servitude, it strictly forbade

cruelty, exploitation, and ruling over anyone with "rigor."

Question: What is the difference between nephesh in Genesis 2:7 and ruach in Ecclesiastes 12:7, and if they are different words why do we still say that no conscious part of a person goes to God at death?

Answer: 'Nephesh' and 'ruach' are not the same word, but they are not describing two conscious parts of a human being either.

'Ruach' is the breath of life, the life-giving power from God that animates the body. That is why Job 33:4 and James 2:26 are brought in. The spirit or breath is what gives life to the body. When that breath is absent, the body is dead.

'Nephesh' is the living person that results when the dust body is animated by that breath. Genesis 2:7 is treated as the composition text: dust plus breath equals a living soul, that is, a living being or person. So man does not have a soul as a detachable conscious entity. Man is a soul.

Ecclesiastes 12:7 gives the reversal of Genesis 2:7. The dust returns to the earth, the breath returns to God who gave it, and the living person no longer exists as a functioning whole. That is death. So the two texts are not fighting each other. One explains how a human being becomes alive, and the other explains what happens when that life-process is undone.

Scripture also uses 'nephesh' in a broader way. It can mean life, person, self, or living being. Abram acquired 'nephesh' in Genesis 12:5, meaning people. The blood is called the 'nephesh' in Deuteronomy 12:23 in the sense of life. In the parable of the rich fool, speaking to his "soul" is simply speaking to himself. The point is that the word does not automatically mean an immortal conscious entity living inside the body.

So when the spirit returns to God in Ecclesiastes 12:7, what returns is not a conscious person traveling to heaven. It is the life that came from God. The conscious person was the composite whole produced by body and breath together.

That is why the thief on the cross is raised near the end. If Jesus had meant that the thief would be with Him in paradise that same day, the rest of the biblical evidence would be broken, because Jesus later said, 'I have not yet ascended to My Father.' So the statement is taken with the punctuation placed differently: Jesus was making the promise that day, not saying the thief entered paradise that day.

So the difference is real: 'ruach' is the animating life-breath from God, while 'nephesh' is the living person produced by that breath and the body together. But that difference does not create room for a conscious immortal soul leaving the body at death. It actually explains why the person ceases to live until the resurrection.

Question: Was Ezekiel 9 fulfilled historically when Babylon destroyed Jerusalem, or is it only a future end-time prophecy?

Answer: Ezekiel 9 had a real historical fulfillment, and it also has a typological end-time application. You do not have to choose one and deny the other.

The historical side is tied to the Babylonian destruction of Jerusalem. The scene in Ezekiel is a real judgment on apostate Jerusalem in which the faithful are marked out and the unfaithful are destroyed. In that sense, the prophecy belongs to its own historical setting.

But historical events in Scripture are often used typologically. What happened locally

with literal Jerusalem and literal Babylon becomes a pattern for the end of time.

That is why Revelation 7 is brought alongside Ezekiel 9. In Ezekiel 9 there is a mark on the forehead. In Revelation 7 there is a seal on the forehead. In both scenes there are two classes. One group is identified as God's faithful people and preserved through judgment, while the other faces destruction.

So the historical fulfillment does not cancel the future application, and the future application does not erase the historical one. The past event is the type; the end-time sealing and judgment are the antitype.

There is no contradiction between Ellen White statements that apply the passage to the destruction under Babylon and statements that apply it to the final crisis. Both uses fit once you recognize the prophetic pattern.

So Ezekiel 9 is not only about the past, and it is not only about the future. It first described a historical judgment on Jerusalem, and then that same pattern is carried forward typologically into the last-day sealing of God's people and the destruction of the unfaithful.

Question: How can I understand the prophecies of Daniel 1-11 and the book of Revelation?

Answer: To understand the prophetic books, you must study them in sequence and recognize their deep interconnectedness. Revelation is the key that unlocks the culmination of Daniel, but Daniel lays the foundation. You cannot study the complexities of Revelation without first mastering Daniel, just as you cannot study trigonometry without first studying basic math.

Start by reading the historical section of Daniel (chapters 1-6). These chapters are not just moral stories; they contain prophetic elements and typological lessons for the last days (for example, Daniel 2 is a foundational prophecy). Once you grasp these basic patterns, move to the purely prophetic sections (chapters 7-12).

As you progress into Revelation, you will discover the prophetic principle of "repeat and enlarge." The visions do not necessarily stack chronologically on top of each other; rather, they return to the same overarching timeline--the great controversy between good and evil--and expand upon it with new details and broader vision. By tracing this sequence from Daniel 2 and 7 through Revelation 12, 13, and finally 17, the full prophetic picture of the end times becomes clear.

Question: What did Jesus mean when He said "Touch Me Not" in John 20:17?

Answer: When Jesus told Mary "touch me not," a better translation from the Greek is "do not cling to me" or "do not detain me." Jesus was not forbidding physical contact entirely--He allowed it later--but He could not be delayed at that specific moment. He had to make a quick ascension to the heavenly courts to present Himself before the Father.

This action was the fulfillment of the Old Testament sanctuary typology. Just as the Passover lamb represented His death and the unleavened bread His burial, the Feast of Firstfruits represented His resurrection. On that day, the priest would wave a sheaf of barley at the entrance to the sanctuary. In fulfillment of this, Jesus went to the entrance of the heavenly sanctuary to present Himself as the firstfruits of the redeemed.

He needed absolute assurance from the Father that His sacrifice was accepted and the

covenant ratified. Once God affirmed that His atonement was ample, Jesus received all authority in heaven and on earth. He then returned to earth the very same day to spend 40 days ministering to His disciples and preparing them for their mission, before His final ascension to begin His high priestly ministry.

Question: When a sinner comes to repentance and turns their life around, is that person still labeled a sinner?

Answer: Technically yes and no -- and that tension is the heart of justification by faith. Romans 5:1 is the ground: "Having been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ." Justification means God looks at the repentant, believing sinner and declares them righteous -- not because sin has ceased, but because Christ's righteousness is credited to their account. Romans 8:1 says it from the other direction: "There is therefore now no condemnation to those who are in Christ Jesus."

Luther captured the paradox in Latin: *simul iustus et peccator* -- at the same time righteous, at the same time a sinner. When is the last time you sinned? You are technically still a sinner. Yet God does not see you through your record; he sees you through Christ, who is your representative and advocate. Romans 4:3 and Galatians 3:5-6 confirm the pattern: Abraham believed God and it was credited to him for righteousness. The credit is real, given in advance of completion.

That is justification. Sanctification is the ongoing process of God making real what he has declared. A new believer is like a child learning to walk -- falls are expected; the question is whether they get up. 1 John 2:1 is the safety net: "If any man sins, we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous." That sits alongside 1 John 3:6 and 3:9, which say those in Christ do not sin -- meaning they do not practice sin, do not wallow in it, do not return to it as a way of life. The two are not in conflict: the Christian falls; the Christian gets up; the Christian is not defined by the fall.

Assurance is not a reward for sinlessness. As long as you cling to Christ, hate sin, and keep repenting -- genuine repentance, not escape from punishment but sorrow that sin offended God and drove Christ to the cross -- the declaration of righteousness stands. You are accepted in the beloved.

Question: Who are the people who claim to be Jews and are not, and what is the synagogue of Satan in Revelation 2:9?

Answer: The phrase appears in exactly two places: Revelation 2:9, the letter to Smyrna, and Revelation 3:9, the letter to Philadelphia. Both say the same thing -- "those who say they are Jews and are not, but are a synagogue of Satan." Reading this as a reference to ethnic Jewish people is to misread the book of Revelation, which is saturated with Old Testament Jewish terminology applied to the church age: Balaam, Jezebel, the synagogue itself -- all Old Testament names and institutions applied to conditions within the Christian church.

The question is then: who is a Jew in the church age? Paul answers it directly. Romans 2:28-29: "He is not a Jew who is one outwardly... but he is a Jew who is one inwardly, and circumcision is that of the heart, in the spirit." Romans 9:6-8: "They are not all Israel who are of Israel." Galatians 3:29: "If you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's seed and heirs according to the promise." A true Jew is one who has received Jesus Christ as Savior and Lord.

John 1:47-49 shows the positive case. Jesus sees Nathanael approaching and says, "Behold, an Israelite indeed in whom there is no deceit" -- and Nathanael confesses him as Son of God, King of Israel. That confession is what makes a true Israelite. John 8:39-44

shows the negative case at full length: Jesus tells the Jewish religious leaders that Abraham is their biological ancestor but not their spiritual father. "If you were Abraham's children, you would do the works of Abraham." They seek to kill him. Their father is the devil. Physical descent is not the issue; doing the works of Abraham -- which includes receiving the Messiah -- is.

The synagogue of Satan is therefore not a building or a formal organization. It is a disposition and a mindset. In the context of the seven churches, Smyrna is the persecuted church. Those who claim to be God's people -- to hold the truth, to be in the covenant -- but reject Christ and align themselves with those opposing the church are the synagogue of Satan. They claim to be Jews; they are not. The lie is the claim.

Question: I am an Adventist who wants to tithe, but my non-Christian husband forbids it and controls our household income. The Bible says to submit to a husband, but also to obey God rather than man. Am I accountable for not tithing? Am I at risk of losing salvation over this?

Answer: Submission to a husband does not extend to disobeying God. Ephesians 5:22 says "wives submit yourselves unto your own husbands as unto the Lord" -- the qualifier matters. The submission is modeled on the wife's submission to the Lord, which means it cannot require what the Lord himself forbids. There is a ceiling on spousal authority, and "obey God rather than man" is that ceiling.

On guilt and salvation: she should not feel condemned. Her heart is right -- she wants to tithe and would if she could. If she has no control whatsoever over the money, God will hold the husband accountable, not her. Accountability tracks with control.

The practical guidance is to pay tithe on what she does control. Both spouses receive separate social security checks; her check is hers. If he gives her money for groceries or household expenses, she can tithe on what passes through her hands. Start there and trust Malachi 3: "Prove me now herewith -- I will open the windows of heaven and pour out a blessing till you have no room to receive it." Bohr illustrates with the widow of Zarephath, who gave Elijah the last of her oil and flour first, and the jar did not run out until rain came. The test of faith has to be made before the balance sheet balances -- that is the whole point.

She should keep speaking to her husband, persistently and with grace. One case was shared where a wife's steady witness over several months wore down a resistant husband; when they began tithing together they saw clear blessings and he eventually came to the church. The principle of the persistent widow applies: consistent, loving appeal, not nagging but earnest witness, often accomplishes what a single confrontation cannot.

Question: In Revelation 17:10, five heads have fallen, one is, and the other has not yet come. If the fifth head is papal Rome and John's vision was written before papal Rome, how is John viewing this after the fifth head has already fallen?

Answer: The answer is in the vantage point of the vision. Revelation 17:1-2 opens with one of the seven bowl angels saying to John, "Come, I will show you the judgment of the great harlot who sits on many waters." John is not viewing this from his own time in the first century. He is being transported to the end time -- to the period when the papacy has recovered from its deadly wound and the multitudes, nations, and tongues are once again supporting her.

From that end-time vantage point, five have already fallen: Babylon, Medo-Persia, Greece, pagan Rome, and papal Rome in its first phase (the phase that ended with the

deadly wound). The sixth -- the papacy in its wounded and diminished state -- "is" in the flow of history between the wound and the healing. The seventh, which "has not yet come" and "must continue a short time," is the fully healed papacy of the final period. John is not confused about chronology; he is simply standing at the end and looking back.

Revelation is not in chronological order. It moves in cycles -- forward to the end, then back to lay the frame of reference, then forward again. To understand Revelation 17, Bohr argues you must work the layered structure: Daniel 2 is the foundation; Daniel 7 expands it; Revelation 12 expands further; Revelation 13 builds on 12; Revelation 17 is the final and fullest expansion. The waters the harlot sits on in Revelation 17 parallel the dragon's flood in Revelation 12 -- the same persecuting power at different stages of history. Only when you see that building pattern does the placement of "five have fallen" make sense -- because you know which sequence of empires has already run its course before the end-time scene.

Question: Are church manuals and books of order replacing the Bible? Are we in danger of putting more authority in them than the Bible, hindering the Protestant principle of Scripture alone by teaching the commandments of men (Matthew 15:3-9)?

Answer: The Seventh-day Adventist Church maintains the firm Protestant position of the Bible and the Bible alone as its supreme authority. The Church Manual and other policy books do not replace, contradict, or supersede Scripture. They are only legitimate insofar as they harmonize with the Word of God.

The purpose of the Church Manual is not to establish new doctrines, but to serve as an operational guide to maintain order, protect sound doctrine, prevent the abuse of authority, and promote global unity. It provides the practical "nuts and bolts" for how the church operates--defining the roles of pastors, elders, and deacons, outlining how to conduct elections and ceremonies, and explaining how to handle church discipline biblically.

There is a clear distinction between the Bible and these manuals. The Church Manual can only be amended by a vote of the full global delegation at a General Conference Session, ensuring broad consensus rather than arbitrary top-down decrees. There are also working policies for day-to-day administration (like salaries and properties) and a Minister's Manual for conducting ceremonies. Problems only arise when these manuals are applied unevenly--such as when local conferences ignore global policies or invent rules to ban speakers improperly. When applied correctly and kept subordinate to the Bible, the manuals are a necessary blessing that keeps a global movement united and functioning smoothly.

Question: I want to tithe, but my non-Christian husband forbids it and controls our combined retirement income. I know a wife should submit to her husband, but we must also obey God rather than men. Am I disobeying God, and will I lose my salvation over this issue?

Answer: This is a serious and difficult situation. The governing biblical principle when human authority contradicts God's commands is found in Acts 5:29: "We ought to obey God rather than men."

One approach is to persistently pray and lovingly but firmly talk to your husband, explaining that withholding the tithe robs God and blocks the financial and spiritual blessings He wants to pour out on your household. Sometimes, a non-believing spouse will eventually relent, allow the tithe to be paid, and subsequently witness God's blessing--which can even lead to their conversion.

However, even if a husband never sees the light, the biblical requirement to be faithful remains. We are approaching a time in earth's history when believers will have to make incredibly tough decisions--choosing whether to serve God or face severe consequences, even the loss of life. If we compromise our faithfulness now under pressure, we are not preparing our characters for the ultimate crunch time ahead.

Question: If the sun stood still for a whole day in Joshua 10:13, would the weekly cycle have been thrown off, making the next Sabbath fall a day late?

Answer: The weekly cycle has not been broken since creation week. That is not negotiable. The question is how to account for Joshua's extra day without disrupting the count -- and the answer lies in how God defines a day.

Ellen White in Testimonies to Ministers page 135 writes that God means "the day of 24 hours which he has marked off by the rising and setting of the sun." On the day of Joshua's battle the sun did not go down and the moon did not move. No sunrise opened it; no sunset closed it. By God's own definition, that interval was not a day. It falls outside the week's count the same way a fraction of time that has no rising and setting simply does not register as a day. The weekly cycle was not interrupted; it ran continuously alongside a period that did not qualify as a day at all.

Ellen White in Signs of the Times, March 20, 1879, confirms the continuity: "The first week in which God performed the work of creation... was just like every other week. The great God in his days of creation and day of rest measured off the first cycle as a sample for successive weeks till the close of time. The weekly cycle of seven literal days... has been preserved and brought down through Bible history." She does not name Joshua as an exception. The cycle held.

Ellen White adds in Patriarchs and Prophets page 509 that this miracle "testifies that the creation is under the control of the creator" -- it was a demonstration of divine authority, not a disruption of divine order.

A practical point on doubt: if Sunday-keepers maintain that the day they keep is the same day Christ rose -- trusting the continuity of the weekly cycle across the centuries -- then the Sabbath must be equally intact. You cannot hold the resurrection-day continuous and the creation-Sabbath scrambled by the same count.

Question: Do 1 Corinthians 10:16 and 1 Corinthians 11:27-29 justify consubstantiation?

Answer: The two texts the questioner cites do not prove consubstantiation, and neither does the rest of Scripture.

1 Corinthians 10:16 asks, "Is it not the communion of the blood of Christ... the communion of the body of Christ?" The word is communion -- participation, memorial identification -- not literalized flesh and blood. 1 Corinthians 11:27-29 warns against eating "in an unworthy manner" and "not discerning the Lord's body." The unworthiness in context is about self-examination, unconfessed sin, and failing to grasp what the symbols represent -- not about failing to chew literal flesh.

John 6 is the decisive passage. When Jesus said "unless you eat my flesh and drink my blood, you have no life in you," many disciples heard it literally and were offended. He clarified in verse 63: "It is the spirit who gives life; the flesh profits nothing. The words that I speak to you are spirit and they are life." Physical eating is explicitly not what he meant. He means receiving him through his word -- assimilating his character and life through Scripture. John 6:66 records that those who refused this interpretation and took it literally walked away and never returned. The literalist reading produced apostasy.

Jesus himself named the Supper a memorial: "Do this in remembrance of me." That is his own definition of the act. Nothing in 1 Corinthians overrides it.

Hebrews 10:10 closes the argument: "By that will we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all." Christ was offered once. Both transubstantiation and consubstantiation implicitly re-present that sacrifice at every table. The typology of Moses and the rock makes the point concrete: Moses was told to speak to the rock the second time but struck it instead -- and Ellen White says he ruined the type, because the rock (representing Christ) was to fall under the rod of judgment only once. The once-for-all sacrifice of Calvary cannot and need not be repeated.

Question: What is your position on deliverance ministry? Is there a rightful place for this within the church?

Answer: Deliverance ministry has a legitimate place in the church, but the term requires careful definition. In its broadest sense all ministry is deliverance ministry: when a person surrenders to Christ, Romans 6:14-16 declares that sin no longer has dominion, and 2 Corinthians 5:17 confirms that former things pass away -- the power of sin is broken. This progressive freedom from sin's power, and eventually its presence, is the biblical shape of deliverance.

The charismatic form -- directly confronting and conversing with demons in others -- does not match the biblical pattern. Acts 19:11-16 is instructive: God worked extraordinary miracles through Paul, but when the seven sons of Sceva attempted to cast out demons using Jesus' name without a personal relationship with him, the evil spirit answered "Jesus I know, and Paul I know -- but who are you?" and overpowered them. The lesson is not that exorcism never occurs but that it requires one's own life to be in order with the Lord and a specific assignment from Christ.

Mark 1:21-27 shows Jesus casting out an unclean spirit with direct authority. The biblical model for ordinary believers is not seeking out demonic confrontations. Through prayer, communion, the anointing of elders, and ongoing relationship with Christ the enemy flees. Deliverance comes through sanctification, not through circuit-riding demon-chasing.

Question: What does buying and selling mean in Revelation 13:17 -- is it literal or spiritual?

Answer: Revelation 13:16-17 states plainly that no one may buy or sell except those who bear the mark of the beast. The restriction is literal: commerce will be closed to those who refuse the mark. But the question of why -- the spiritual condition that triggers the literal consequence -- is what Proverbs 23:23 unlocks.

"Buy the truth and sell it not," Proverbs says. In the final crisis the truth at stake is the Sabbath -- God's seal -- versus the mark of the beast, which is knowingly keeping Sunday when the Sabbath is the day of rest. Those who buy the truth embrace God's seal and accept the economic death decree that follows. Those who sell the truth accept the mark and gain commercial access. As Bohr puts it: you can buy the truth and be under a death decree, or you can sell the truth and be spared the death decree.

The answer is therefore not either/or -- it is both/and. The commercial restriction is real and literal. The reason for it is spiritual. The two levels are inseparable: the literal buying and selling maps directly onto a spiritual transaction over the truth.

Question: Who is the woman clothed with the sun in Revelation 12, and what do the

moon and the 12 stars on her head represent?

Answer: In Revelation 12:1-2 a woman appears clothed with the sun, the moon under her feet, and a crown of twelve stars -- she is in labor. The woman in Revelation represents the church. A pregnant church births only one thing: Christ.

The twelve stars represent the twelve foundational figures of God's people across both Testaments -- the twelve patriarchs who founded the Old Testament church, and the twelve apostles who founded the New Testament church. The number twelve spans all of redemptive history. Ellen White confirms this at Acts of the Apostles page 16: "As in the Old Testament, the twelve patriarchs stood as representatives of Israel, so the twelve apostles stand as representatives of the gospel church." And at page 18: "It was at the ordination of the twelve that the first step was taken in the organization of the church that after Christ's departure was to carry on his work on the earth."

The sun the woman wears represents the fulfillment of the Old Testament -- Christ as the greater light. The moon under her feet represents the Old Testament itself, a reflected light whose shadows and types pointed forward to the sun. The Old Testament bore witness to the light; the New Testament is that light's arrival. Jesus Christ is the chief cornerstone on which both the twelve patriarchs and the twelve apostles rest.

Question: If Adam and Eve were perfectly created in a perfect garden, why would God ask them to tend and keep it? How does one maintain something already perfect?

Answer: Perfection does not mean maintenance-free. The garden of Eden required tending -- pruning branches, planting, care -- but the work was pleasant and invigorating, not burdensome.

This labor was God's gift to Adam for three reasons. First, it gave him purpose and occupation. Murray notes that every creature of God has a purpose; idleness is not a blessing. Second, it kept him engaged and delighted. Ellen White (Story of Redemption, page 21) writes: "A portion of their time was to be occupied in the happy employment of dressing the garden. Their labor was not wearisome but pleasant and invigorating." Third, employment was how Adam could exercise his capacities and find happiness -- to "call into exercise the wonderful organs of the body" (Our High Calling, page 223).

The key distinction is between pre-sin and post-sin labor. Genesis 3:19 establishes the post-Fall curse: "in the sweat of thy face shall you eat bread." Before sin, the same work -- pruning, beautifying, maintaining -- was pleasant. After sin it became toilsome. Eden's labor was intentional stewardship of what was perfect, keeping it in pristine condition.

Even in the eternal ages to come, occupations continue. As Revelation 16:15 says we must keep our garments clean, so Adam and Eve kept the garden -- perfect, if you please. Maintaining perfection is an active responsibility, not an oxymoron.

Question: Why do Adventists teach that the little horn of Daniel 8 is not Antiochus Epiphanes, especially given that Jesus himself attended the feast of dedication (John 10:22) commemorating the Jews' deliverance from Antiochus and restoration of the sanctuary?

Answer: The identification of Daniel 8's little horn as Antiochus Epiphanes fails on theological, chronological, and exegetical grounds.

The little horn of Daniel 8 is the same little horn of Daniel 7 -- not a horn emerging from one of the four Greek kingdoms themselves. Bohr argues that the traditional identification of the four horns as Alexander's four generals is incorrect: one of those four

horns is actually Pergamum, located in Asia Minor, which was the historical origin of pagan Rome and later papal Rome. The little horn of Daniel 8 therefore represents Roman power growing out of Pergamum, not a Seleucid king.

The sanctuary in Daniel 8:14 to be "cleansed" cannot be the earthly temple in Jerusalem. That temple was destroyed in AD 70. By the end of the 2300-day prophecy no physical sanctuary would exist to cleanse. The sanctuary in view is the heavenly one, which operates during the Christian dispensation. Jesus's attendance at the feast of dedication (John 10:22) -- commemorating Antiochus's overthrow and the temple rededication -- is merely a historical fact about what feast Jesus attended. It does not establish that the little horn prophecy refers to Antiochus.

The 2300 "evenings and mornings" cannot be literal 24-hour days. Applied literally they lead nowhere prophetically -- they just stop. The year-day principle supported in Numbers 4, Ezekiel 4, and Numbers 14 must apply. Since the 70 weeks cut off from the 2300 days are themselves weeks of years and not literal weeks, the entire prophecy operates on the year-day scale.

Finally, the vision explicitly extends to "the time of the end" -- a scope too broad to fit within a few centuries of the prophecy's writing. Antiochus Epiphanes was historically one of the weaker Seleucid rulers, not the super-powerful horn the prophecy describes. While Josephus interpreted the horn as Antiochus, 2,000 more years of theological study has refined understanding well beyond ancient sources.

Question: As Adventists we believe the judgment began in 1844. Others -- evangelicals and some former Adventists such as Desmond Ford -- believe the judgment begins right after the resurrection of Christ in 31 AD. Can you reconcile these two ideas with biblical text? Which one is true?

Answer: A trial has three stages: investigation of the evidence, verdict or sentence, and execution of the sentence. God's judgment follows that biblical pattern. He does not simply declare someone saved or lost; there is a universe to convince that God has been right in every case, and that must happen before the second coming.

The judgment is future. Revelation 14:7 declares, "fear God and give glory to him, for the hour of his judgment has come" -- and right after that message you see Jesus coming in the second coming. The judgment did not take place in New Testament times. Paul in Acts 17:31 says, "because he has appointed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by the man whom he has ordained. He has given assurance of this to all by raising him from the dead." So there is a day when he will judge the world, and that day had not yet arrived in the apostles' day.

Ellen White tells us that judgment would take place 300 years after Luther. The sanctuary message brings the picture of how and when judgment happens, and Daniel helps us understand where, why, and when.

The Bible is full of the concept of investigative judgment. It begins in the Garden of Eden: after Adam and Eve sinned, God comes and says, "Where are you?" He knew where Adam was -- he is calling him to the judgment seat. "Have you eaten from the tree?" The examination is being made. Then God pronounces the sentence. The Tower of Babel: God says, "let's go down and see if they have gone too far." God knew, but he is teaching us the way judgment is performed. Genesis 18: Abraham intercedes, "Will not the judge of the earth do what is right?" God says, "I'm going to go down and see if the cities have gone too far." Once again, an investigation of the case.

In the New Testament, the man who came to the party without the wedding garment,

the good and bad fish, the wheat and tares, the wise and foolish virgins, and the forgiveness that can be revoked all illustrate that judgment examines works to prove the reality of commitment.

The judgment takes place in three stages. First, the pre-advent investigative judgment -- only those who claim the name of Jesus, who claim to have the righteousness of Christ, are examined before the second coming. Jesus must determine whom he has a right to take to heaven before he comes. Second, the millennial judgment -- all the wicked are dead on earth, Satan and his angels are bound, and God proves to the righteous in heaven that he was correct in leaving everyone behind. Third, after the millennium, God opens the books in panoramic view and shows the wicked why they are lost, including the full history of Satan and his angels. When it is over, every knee bows and every tongue confesses that God did it right. Only at that moment can God destroy sin and sinners.

Question: Concerning Revelation 1:7 -- "every eye will see him, even those that pierced him." We believe those who crucified Christ will be resurrected to see his coming. When they receive the second death, will it actually be their third death? This verse says "every eye will see him" -- will the righteous dead see Jesus approaching with the clouds, or only once he arrives and is in the clouds?

Answer: The Bible does not speak of a third death. It speaks of first death -- physical death, which everyone will suffer except the end-time generation -- and second death, which is everlasting death. Physical death is not eternal. In the case of the second coming, several groups must be kept in mind. Those who are alive will see Jesus come in the clouds. There is also a specialized group of dead -- those who pierced him -- who will resurrect. And there is a group of righteous people -- those who died in the faith of the third angel's message -- who resurrect at the voice of God before Jesus even begins his second coming. Then when Jesus is above the earth, the other righteous dead resurrect. They are not going to see the entire second coming from beginning to end.

In short, this special group of wicked people who pierced Christ will have three deaths in sequence: they died before the second coming, they resurrect in the special resurrection, they die again, and then after the panoramic view they suffer the second death. Even though we might say technically it is a third death in sequence, in the biblical definition it is second death because it is death from which there will be no resurrection.

Regarding whether they will see Jesus approaching -- they will see him when Jesus is about to begin his second coming. Ellen White makes it clear this special group resurrects under the seventh plague, at the voice of God. Then Jesus begins his second coming. Christ told them prophetically what they would see: according to Matthew 26:64, Jesus said to Caiaphas, "From now on I tell you that you will see the Son of Man coming on the clouds of heaven with power and glory." So yes, they will see him approach and realize that Christ was indeed the Messiah, the King of kings.